

IT Incident and Service Request Handbook

Ticket quality, categorization, prioritization, troubleshooting notes, and escalation

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Important: Northstar Digital Services is a fictional company created solely for RAG, document retrieval, citation, and corporate AI training exercises. These procedures are illustrative and are not instructions for any real organization.

1. Purpose

This handbook explains how NDS employees and support analysts should record IT incidents and service requests. It aims to make tickets actionable, route them to the right team, and preserve a clear history of diagnosis and resolution. The scenarios and targets are fictional training examples.

2. Incident versus service request

Type	Definition	Example
Incident	An unplanned interruption or reduction in quality of an IT service	VPN stops connecting; email service unavailable
Service request	A standard request for information, access, equipment or an approved service	Request access to a project workspace; request approved software
Security incident	Suspected or confirmed compromise, data exposure, malicious activity or policy breach	Unexpected MFA prompts; lost laptop; suspicious attachment opened
Problem record	A record used to investigate an underlying cause of one or more incidents	Recurring VPN disconnects across a site

3. Minimum ticket information

- **Short title:** identify the affected service and symptom, such as “VPN disconnects every few minutes — remote user”.
- **Description:** explain what happened, what was expected, when it started, and whether it is reproducible.
- **Impact:** number of affected users, business process affected, location/team if relevant, and available workaround.
- **Environment:** device asset tag, operating system, application/client version, network type, and environment (development/test/production) when applicable.
- **Evidence:** exact error text, timestamp and time zone, sanitized screenshot, relevant correlation/request ID, and steps already tried.
- **Security:** use the approved security incident process for suspected compromise. Do not paste passwords, tokens, secrets, full payment details, or unnecessary personal data into a ticket.

4. Illustrative priority model

Priority	Impact and urgency	Example	Handling guidance
P1 — Critical	Widespread outage; critical business function blocked; no safe workaround	Company-wide authentication outage	Notify incident manager/on-call team immediately; coordinate updates
P2 — High	Multiple users or a time-sensitive team significantly impaired	VPN unavailable for a delivery team	Route to resolver group promptly; confirm scope and workaround
P3 — Normal	Individual or limited impact; workaround available	One employee's VPN client fails	Standard queue; collect diagnostics and troubleshoot

Priority	Impact and urgency	Example	Handling guidance
P4 — Low	Minor inconvenience or information request	How-to question with no service interruption	Knowledge article or normal service-request workflow

These categories are examples, not binding service-level commitments. A security incident may require immediate escalation regardless of the routine incident priority.

5. Ticket lifecycle

1 — Log and acknowledge

Create a record, confirm the requester can be contacted, and provide the ticket number.

2 — Categorize and prioritize

Select the affected service and issue category. Assess impact, urgency, scope, and security implications.

3 — Search knowledge

Search approved knowledge articles for known issues and validated workarounds. Confirm that the article matches the system/version and is current.

4 — Perform safe initial diagnosis

Ask focused questions, review approved status dashboards and logs, and perform only authorized troubleshooting steps.

5 — Route or escalate

Assign to the resolver group with the evidence collected, actions taken, and a clear question or requested action.

6 — Communicate updates

Tell the requester what is known, what is being investigated, any safe workaround, and when the next update is expected.

7 — Validate resolution

Confirm the service works or the request was completed. Record the actual fix and any remaining limitations.

8 — Close and learn

Document the resolution, link related incidents or problem records, and suggest a knowledge article when the issue is likely to recur.

6. Example: good versus poor ticket

Poor ticket: "VPN broken. Please fix."

Improved ticket: "SecureConnect disconnects approximately every 5–10 minutes on a company-managed Windows laptop. Started 09:20 IST today. Internet remains available; reconnect works temporarily. Client version 5.4. Error shown: 'Tunnel connection interrupted'. One user affected; remote work is delayed. Tried one reconnect and restarted the approved client. No security controls were changed. Please investigate connectivity/client logs."

7. Escalation rules

- Escalate suspected credential compromise, unexpected MFA prompts, data exposure, malware, or a lost device through the security incident route immediately.

- Escalate widespread outages to the incident manager and relevant on-call team; do not wait for each user to file an individual ticket before following the major-incident process.
- Escalate when a documented safe workaround fails, the issue is outside the support team's authority, or privileged access is required.
- Include the business impact, affected population, timestamps, evidence, tests performed, and what decision or action is needed from the next team.

8. Knowledge management standards

- Articles need an owner, title, service/category, version, review date, and applicable system or client version.
- Separate symptoms, prerequisites, steps, expected results, warnings, and escalation criteria into clearly labeled sections.
- Prefer one procedure per article and use exact names for tools and error messages.
- Retire obsolete articles or clearly mark them superseded; do not allow an old workaround to appear as current guidance.
- Do not put secrets, live credentials, sensitive customer data, or unapproved internal-only details in general knowledge articles.

9. Frequently asked questions

Should every VPN complaint be P1?

No. Prioritize based on the number of affected users, business impact, urgency, workaround availability and security implications.

What if I do not know the root cause?

Record observed facts and tests, not guesses. Route the ticket to the appropriate resolver team.

Can I close a ticket once I send instructions?

Follow the support team's closure process and, where required, confirm the requester has validated the resolution.

What if the ticket contains a password?

Do not repeat or forward the secret. Follow the approved security procedure for removing or containing exposed credentials and notify the appropriate team.

When should a recurring issue become a problem record?

When multiple incidents share a pattern or the underlying cause needs investigation beyond resolving an individual occurrence.

10. Analyst handoff checklist

- ■ Service and category selected
- ■ Impact, urgency and scope recorded
- ■ Timestamp/time zone included
- ■ Relevant device/client versions recorded
- ■ Safe troubleshooting steps documented
- ■ Sensitive information excluded
- ■ Correct resolver group selected

- ■ Requester updated with next step